EDITION 34

# Most ”the model is wrong” bugs are in the data, not the model.

*I built an app to keep my household's money honest. For a while its forecast was confidently, beautifully wrong. It told us we were getting richer than we were.*

A **7**-part breakdown

SWIPE >>>>

0101 / 07

# The setup.

I built a small app to track our debts, accounts, recurring bills and a long-range projection. Real backend, real database, row-level security, real users. Us.

0202 / 07

# The symptom.

The forecast was confidently wrong. It told us we were getting richer than we were, by a lot, and it compounded that story out thirty years.

0303 / 07

# The hunt.

I went looking for why. The bug was in one line. Monthly surplus was income minus recurring expenses, and the recurring table only held our two paychecks. No expenses.

0404 / 07

# How a small gap becomes a fantasy.

So the engine thought nearly all our income was investable surplus, then compounded the fiction for three decades. A small data gap became a six-figure fantasy.

# Fix the data first.

I derived real spending from actual transactions, split true living costs from the once-a-year property-tax lump, and entered the real rows. The surplus snapped back to something honest.

0606 / 07

# Then fix the logic.

Use each debt's real interest rate instead of a hardcoded guess, and route surplus to the highest-rate debt first, the way you'd actually pay it down. Order mattered: data before logic.

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# Save this.

A flawless formula over garbage inputs gives you a confident wrong answer. That is more dangerous than an obvious one. Check the data before you blame the model.

THE TAKEAWAY

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◆ Joseph Bankole



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